Three Reflections on the Bharat Jodo Yatra

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Before the Yatra Began: Why Jodo Bharat?

Yusuf Meherally was not even forty when he wrote and circulated the booklet titled ‘Quit India’ in August 1942. By then he had been imprisoned several times for espousing independence. He had also been the youngest mayor of Bombay (now Mumbai) and had become immensely popular for his administrative efficiency and welfare measures. Incidentally, it was Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel who had thought of nominating the youthful Yusuf as a candidate for the mayoral elections. On 14 July, a meeting of the Congress was held at Wardha, in which four resolutions were passed: 1. An immediate end to British colonial rule over India. 2. Freeing India’s declaration of commitment to defend itself from all types of fascism and imperialism. 3. After the British withdrawal, a provisional government of India to be formed. 4. A civil disobedience movement against British rule. Before giving effect to the first resolution, a name reflecting the spirit of the resolutions had to be given to the movement envisioned in the fourth resolution. In preference over all other suggestions presented in the discussion about the name, Yusuf Meherally’s suggestion to call it the ‘Quit India’ agitation received Gandhi’s approval.

The movement was launched on 8 August 1942, and was brutally suppressed by the colonial government. Around one lakh people were arrested, many were lathi-charged, huge fines were imposed and the Indian National Congress (INC) was declared an unlawful association. Almost the entire leadership of the INC was arrested without any trial within hours of